

V2. Website

1. HOME

Project Neer

Mapping Water Heritage

Water remembers.

It remembers the fields it fed, the temples it circled, the hands that tended its banks at dawn. It remembers every community that built its life around it, every name it was given, every ritual performed at its edge.

We are mapping that memory. And we are inviting everyone who carries one to add it here.

[Explore the Map](#)

[Add Your Site](#)

2. MAPPING WATER

Not all heritage looks like heritage.

Some of it is grand. Most of it isn't. A low mud bund holding back a field. A tank so familiar to its village that no one thinks to photograph it. A spring with a name that lives only in the mouths of elders. A channel, hand-cut, still flowing, still feeding.

These are not lesser places. They are the places that kept people alive. That still do.

Water heritage is not defined by age or architecture. It is defined by what a place carries. The knowledge embedded in how it was built. The community memory wrapped around how it was maintained. The ecological wisdom that no textbook recorded because no one thought to ask. In a changing climate, all of that is not just history. It is instruction.

This map is our attempt to hold it. A growing, living record of Tamil Nadu's water heritage, built not by institutions but by the people who know these places best. By you.

Put your water site on the map.

It might be a tank you bathed in as a child. A sacred pond that appears on no official record. A river bend your village has always gathered at. A structure so humble it has never been photographed.

Drop a pin. Give it a name. Add what you know, whether that is one sentence or a lifetime of memory.

Every pin is an act of conservation.

[Add a Water Site](#)

3. ABOUT

It begins with a river.

The Tamiraparani flows through the Porunai basin, through Tirunelveli, through the memory of every family that has ever lived on its banks. For our founders, that is not geography. That is ancestry.

This project grew from that intimacy. From the understanding that water systems are not merely ecological. They are the shape of a civilisation. The record of how people organised themselves, fed themselves, and made meaning together across centuries.

Tamil Nadu's water heritage is vast and so much of it exists outside the boundaries of what we have been taught to call heritage. No grand façade. No protected status. Just structures and systems that have quietly held communities together for generations, now facing encroachment, neglect, and a climate that is changing faster than we can keep up.

4. Our founders

Saranya Dharshini

Saranya is an architect and conservation specialist with over fifteen years of experience working across India and the UK. As Vice President of ICOMOS International Scientific Committee on Water and Heritage, she works at the intersection of policy, place, and people. Her expertise spans UNESCO World Heritage Sites, historic and scared architecture, museum design, and architectural conservation. Guided by a philosophy of giving back to society, she advocates for people-centred conservation practices anchored in traditional knowledge systems and community engagement.

K. Porchelvi

Porchelvi spent her career in education, retiring as a headmistress. She is Vice President of the Tamil Writers Society and carries within her a living archive of Tamil literature, oral histories, and the stories that pass between generations. She knows what was handed down and understands, with quiet urgency, why it cannot stop here.

5. COLLECTIVE

No river runs alone.

Behind Project Neer is a wider circle. Researchers and conservationists. Historians and teachers. Writers and farmers. People who grew up near water and never quite left it behind.

We bring different knowledge and ask each other hard questions. We share what we find and sit with what we don't understand.

6. CONTRIBUTE

You are carrying something this atlas needs.

A place name that exists only in your family. A tank that has no entry in any government record. A water site you pass every day without realising what it once was, or still is.

That knowledge is not small. It is exactly what Project Neer runs on.

Add your site to the map. Just a location, a name, whatever photograph or story you have. Even a fragment counts. Even something half-remembered.

Water memory is made of exactly those fragments.

Add a Water Site

You can also write to us. Point us toward a community whose water knowledge we should know about. Share a story that doesn't fit neatly into a pin on a map. We want to hear all of it.

Get in Touch

7. CONTACT

Come find us.

With a site, a story, a question, or an idea. With something you've been holding that you think belongs here. With a collaboration that could take this further than we've imagined.

This project is made of what people bring to it. We hope you'll bring something too.

Water memory belongs to all of us.

[Contact form or email]

Project Neer

Mapping Water Heritage

Water remembers.

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Documentation in progress. Always will be.